

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN RWANDA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action shapes what happens to the hills, wetlands, and communities of Rwanda — but here the challenge is unusual, because the harms that most affect communities often come wrapped in genuinely celebrated green development and conservation, and because Rwanda is a tightly organised state with real environmental achievements but limited space for open dissent. Rwanda is admired around the world as a green model: it has protected its mountain gorillas back from the brink, set aside nearly two-fifths of its land for conservation, banned plastic bags, kept its capital famously clean, and is restoring the wetlands of Kigali to hold back floods. It has protected its mountain gorillas back from the very brink of extinction, set aside nearly two-fifths of its national land for conservation, banned the plastic bag, kept its capital city famously clean and orderly, banned the plastic bag outright, kept its capital city famously clean and orderly, and is restoring the degraded wetlands of Kigali to hold back the floods. These are real achievements, and this guide honours them. These are real and hard-won achievements, and this guide honours them plainly and without reservation. These are real and genuinely hard-won achievements, and this guide honours them plainly and without any reservation whatsoever. Yet the same top-down drive that delivers them can fall heavily on communities: Yet the same strong, top-down drive that delivers these achievements can also fall heavily on ordinary communities: the wetland restorations and green-city projects have evicted residents and expropriated plots; expropriation and resettlement for development and for the clearing of high-risk zones displace families; the wetland restorations and the green-city projects have evicted residents and expropriated their plots; the expropriation and resettlement carried out for development and for the clearing of high-risk zones displace families from their homes; and, in an older pattern, conservation itself has pushed communities from lands they depended on. And, in an older and harder pattern, conservation itself has pushed communities from the very lands they long depended on for their survival. The distinctive difficulty here is that the destructive project is often a good project done in a way that harms the community. The distinctive difficulty here is that the destructive project is very often a genuinely good project carried out in a way that harms the community — a wetland park that floods a neighbourhood with eviction notices, a conservation scheme that excludes the people who lived beside it. A wetland park that floods an entire neighbourhood with eviction notices, or a conservation scheme that quietly excludes the very people who once lived beside it. This guide will be honest that Rwanda's green projects are genuinely valuable, that the state has real reasons for them, that the space for open opposition is constrained, and that the model is entrenched and celebrated; but it will show that the levers here — the state's own promise that green development benefits communities, the rights to fair compensation and consent, the principle of benefit-sharing, and the safeguards of the international funders — are real, and that the aim is not to oppose green development but to insist it be done with communities, not to them.

The Rwandan story teaches two things about defending communities here, and this guide states both plainly. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever pressed together. The second is distinctly Rwandan, and it is what gives this guide its particular character. **Because the harm often comes wrapped in celebrated green development, the task is not to oppose the greening but to insist it be just: to hold the state to its own promise that green**

projects benefit communities, to demand fair compensation and genuine consent, to press for real benefit-sharing and participation, and to invoke the safeguards of the international funders. That combination — the state's own community-benefit promise, the compensation and consent rights, the benefit-sharing, and the donor safeguards — is the distinctive lever here, and this guide is built around it, because in a celebrated green state, the strongest ground is not to fight the green goal but to insist the community share in it fairly and by consent.

But the same story carries honest qualifications this guide states plainly and takes seriously. **The green projects are genuinely valuable, the state has real reasons, the space is constrained, and the model is entrenched.** The wetland restorations really do hold back floods that cause tens of millions in damage, the gorilla conservation really is a success, and the state pursues these with genuine environmental and developmental purpose, so opposition must be careful not to oppose the green goal itself but only its unjust execution; civil society and political space are limited, so the work runs through official, technical, and international channels rather than open confrontation, and with care; and the developmental model is deeply entrenched and internationally admired, so change comes at the margins of execution, not to the model itself. This guide does not pretend the green projects are bad, or that the state lacks reasons, or that open opposition is free. What it shows is how, through the state's own community-benefit promise, the compensation and consent rights, the benefit-sharing, and the donor safeguards, communities can insist that green development be done justly — carefully, within the system, and honouring the real value of the green goals.

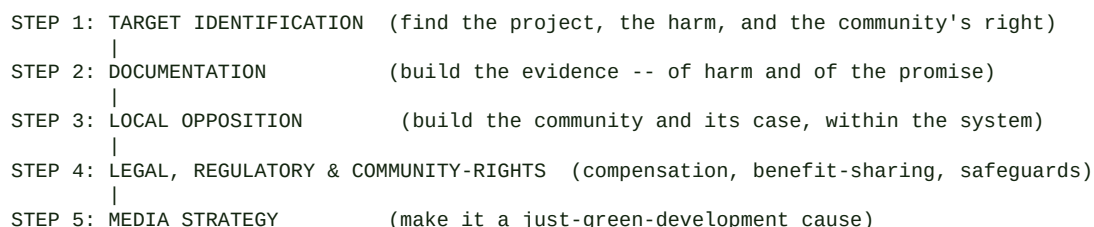
Most people affected by Rwanda's green development do not know HOW to use the levers a celebrated green state offers. They receive the eviction notice for the wetland park, the expropriation order for the development, the exclusion from the conserved land — and either accept it as the price of a green and orderly nation, or resent the greening itself, which is both futile and misdirected, and rarely grasp the levers that work: the state's own promise of community benefit, the rights to compensation and consent, the benefit-sharing, the donor safeguards. The gap between a community displaced and a community included is here often a gap of method — the method of using the state's own community-benefit promise, the compensation and consent rights, the benefit-sharing, and the donor safeguards together.

This guide shows what can actually be tried — inside the Rwandan reality as it is, which is a celebrated, tightly organised green state where harm comes wrapped in good projects and open dissent is constrained. It is written for the person — in a community facing eviction or exclusion, in Rwanda's technical and civil-society world, or among its international funders — who sees a green project fall unjustly on a community and wants to know what can be done in a state where the green goal is genuine but the execution can harm. The answer is a qualified yes: the levers are real — the state's own community-benefit promise, the compensation and consent rights, the benefit-sharing, and the donor safeguards — with the honest qualifiers that the green projects are valuable, the state has reasons, the space is constrained, and the model is entrenched, so the work is careful, within-system insistence that green development be just, not opposition to the green goal. A note on who this guide is for, and on the spirit in which it should be used, because the Rwandan case is particular and easily misunderstood. It is for the person — a member of a community facing eviction, expropriation, or exclusion, a technical or legal adviser, or someone connected to the international funders — willing to do the patient, careful, within-system work of insisting that green development be just, rather than either resenting the greening itself or courting an open confrontation that a tightly organised state makes both ineffective and risky. That is not a lesser form of action but, in Rwanda's conditions, the effective and the honest one, because here the green goals are genuinely valuable and the levers that deliver are the community's rights, the state's own promise, and the funders' safeguards, all reached through the system rather than against it. Anyone who approaches Rwanda

looking to oppose its greening will find themselves both wrong on the merits and weak in the fight; anyone who approaches it insisting that the greening be just — that the community be compensated, consulted, and included — stands on the firm ground of the state's own values. This guide is an honest map of that path: the path of winning a community its rightful place in a green future it has every reason to want.

The Strategic Framework

Effective efforts follow the same underlying pattern, adapted to insisting that green development be just:



These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. The evidence of harm feeds the community-benefit promise, the compensation rights, and the donor safeguards at once; the community organises within the system's limits; a claim for compensation, a demand for participation, or an appeal to a funder's safeguards is both pressure and a spur to the next. The effort that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, gives itself the best — if still difficult — chance of making green development just.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Rwanda's — a celebrated green state that promises community benefit — give a distinctive set:

- **The state's own community-benefit promise.** Rwanda's **stated commitment that green development benefits communities** is a promise it can be held to — the distinctive lever.
- **The compensation and consent rights.** The **rights to fair compensation and genuine consultation** in expropriation and resettlement are real, if imperfectly honoured.
- **The benefit-sharing.** The **principle that communities share in conservation and green projects** — the revenue-sharing model — can be pressed to be real.
- **The donor safeguards.** The **social and environmental safeguards of the international funders** of the green projects can be invoked.
- **The genuine environmental value.** Because the green goal is real, the strongest ground is **insisting it be done justly**, not opposing it.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers prevail, or that the green projects are not valuable. The green projects are **genuinely good**; the state has **real reasons**; the space is **constrained**; and the model is **entrenched**. This guide takes those limits seriously — it states them plainly, and it honours the green goals — and shows how to use the real tools this situation offers — the state's own community-benefit promise, the compensation and consent rights, the benefit-sharing, and the donor safeguards — to make green development just, honestly acknowledging the value of the green projects, the state's reasons, the constrained space, and the entrenchment of the model.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see — and here you must see that the levers run through a celebrated green state's own promises, not against its green goals. Before you spend a single week, map who actually decides a project's fate, at which level, and where the leverage is real. And map where the state's own community-benefit promise, the compensation and consent rights, the benefit-sharing, and the donor safeguards apply, because in Rwanda a harmful project is met not by open confrontation, which is constrained, nor by opposing the green goal, which is misdirected, but by insisting the project be done justly — with fair compensation, genuine consent, real benefit-sharing, and the funders' safeguards honoured.

The Levels of Decision

A Rwandan project runs through a highly organised, mostly state-directed system.

The state and its agencies. The **state, the environment authority, and the development agencies** drive and decide the green and development projects, and are the authority to be persuaded — on their own promise of community benefit — rather than confronted.

The districts and local government. The **districts and local authorities** implement the projects and the expropriations, and are the level at which much of the harm and the remedy occur.

The community-benefit and compensation framework. The **revenue-sharing, compensation, and consultation rules** are the state's own commitments, and a real channel, since holding the state to them is the surest path.

The international funders. The **international funders and their safeguards** — the environment and development bodies financing the green projects — carry social and environmental protections communities can invoke.

Civil society and community. The **community, the technical experts, and what civil society exists** can act within the system's limits to document and advocate.

The Journey of a Project

A Rwandan project — a wetland restoration with evictions, an expropriation for development, a conservation scheme that excludes — moves from a state plan and a green or developmental purpose, through the districts and the compensation process, toward the built project or the protected community, with the **community-benefit promise, the compensation rights, the benefit-sharing, and the donor safeguards** able to intervene. **The compensation rights and the community-benefit promise are where the harm is best met, and the benefit-sharing and the donor safeguards are what make the project just** — and using them together, within the system, is the distinctive Rwandan approach. The distinctive levers are the **community-benefit promise, the compensation and consent rights, the benefit-sharing, and the donor safeguards**. Find out exactly where the project stands, and, crucially, **what community it harms and how, what the state's own promise and the compensation rules require, and how the benefit-sharing and the donor safeguards can be brought to bear**, because those are where a project can genuinely be made just.

Follow the Project, the Promise, and the Community

Behind a project stand the state, its green or developmental purpose, and the community at stake. Trace who decides, who benefits, who is harmed, and — importantly here — **what the state's own community-benefit promise says, what compensation and consent the rules require, how the community can share in the benefit, and what the funders' safeguards demand**. Two questions unlock most Rwandan efforts: **Who is harmed, and what does the state's own promise of community benefit**

require? and **Which lever — the promise, the compensation, the benefit-sharing, the safeguards — can make it just?** The community-benefit promise, the compensation rights, and the donor safeguards are, together, the heart of most such efforts here. Everything else in a Rwandan effort ultimately serves these: the documentation exists to establish the harm against the state's own promise; the within-system community exists to press its rights and its share; and the media, largely through funders and international channels, exists to hold the green brand to its word. Keep the community-benefit promise, the compensation rights, and the donor safeguards at the centre of every claim, submission, and appeal, and the effort retains a clear spine that runs from a single evicted household to the state's own promise that green development serves communities, and that grounds the whole effort in the rights, the promise, and the safeguards the state and its funders have themselves accepted.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that shape a project, because they are the levers — and in a green state they centre on its own promises. The **state, the environment authority, and the development agencies**; the **districts and local government**; the **community-benefit and compensation framework**; the **international funders and their safeguards**; and the **community, the experts, and civil society**. In Rwanda, the **community-benefit promise, the compensation and consent rights, the benefit-sharing, and the donor safeguards** are the most distinctive levers, and they run through the state's own commitments and the funders' rules. Each is a separate front, and a project shown to harm a community against the state's own promise of benefit, without fair compensation or consent, and in breach of the funders' safeguards, can genuinely be pressed toward justice — through the compensation process, the benefit-sharing, and the safeguards — though, honestly, the green projects are valuable, the state has reasons, the space is constrained, and the model is entrenched, and this guide will keep saying so, and keep working carefully within the system.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit effort, calibrate honestly — and here that means acknowledging that the green projects are genuinely valuable, that the state has real reasons, and that the space is constrained, even as the community-benefit promise, the compensation rights, and the donor safeguards give real leverage. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how community-and-development conflicts tend to go in Rwanda and comparable states, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the harm can be **documented and shown to breach the state's own promise or the funders' safeguards**, whether the **compensation, consent, and benefit-sharing** can be pressed, and whether the **donor safeguards** can be invoked. Where the state's own promise is clear and the safeguards apply, the levers here are real; but temper every figure with the honest knowledge that the green goal is valued, the model is entrenched, and space is constrained.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	15–25%	weeks	low	Basis for every other step
Compensation / consent claim	40–60%	months–years	low–moderate	Fair compensation or process won
Community-benefit promise	35–55%	months–years	low	The state's own promise invoked

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Benefit-sharing / participation	35–55%	months–years	low	The community's share made real
Donor-safeguards route	40–60%	months–years	low	Funder's protections enforced
Technical / institutional	30–50%	months–years	low	The project improved within the system
International attention	30–50%	months	low	The green brand's promise pressed
All levers together	35–55%	months–years	moderate	Green development made just for the community

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Rwanda's real strengths for a community are the state's own commitments and the funders' rules: the **community-benefit promise**, the **compensation rights**, the **benefit-sharing**, and the **donor safeguards**. Its constraints are specific and honest: the green projects are **valued**, the state has **real reasons**, the space is **constrained**, and the model is **entrenched** — so progress comes through the state's own promises, the compensation rights, the benefit-sharing, and the donor safeguards, not through opposing the green goal or open confrontation.

*A note on cost and risk: most levers here — a compensation claim, an appeal to the state's promise, an approach to a funder's safeguards — cost mainly organisation, knowledge, and persistence. The scarce resources are **the technical and legal capacity, the connection to the international funders, and the careful navigation of the system** — much of it reachable through the donors and what civil society and legal aid exist. This shapes where a Rwandan effort should concentrate its energy. Because the decisive resources are legal and technical capacity to press a compensation claim, connection to the international funders whose safeguards can be invoked, and the judgement to navigate a constrained state safely — rather than the mass mobilisation that other struggles require and that here would be both constrained and risky — an effort's most valuable investments are in securing good legal and technical help, building a channel to the relevant funders, and documenting the claim rigorously. A small, well-advised community that can press a solid compensation claim, invoke a funder's safeguards, and hold the state to its own promise can accomplish far more, and far more safely, than any attempt at open opposition. The resources that matter most are thus largely a matter of legal and technical capacity, funder connection, and careful judgement — all reachable through the donors and what legal aid and civil society exist, and all within the grasp of a determined and well-advised community. And because the state prizes its green and community-benefiting reputation, the arguments that hold it to its own promise, rather than attack the green goal, are the most persuasive and the safest way in.*

Effectiveness Visualization

COMMUNITY-BENEFIT PROMISE + COMPENSATION + BENEFIT-SHARING + SAFEGUARDS:

Compensation / consent claim: ■■■■■■■■■■ 40-60%

Donor-safeguards route: ■■■■■■■■■■ 40-60%

Community-benefit promise: ■■■■■■■■■■ 35-55%

Benefit-sharing / participate: ■■■■■■■■■■ 35-55%

Technical / institutional: ■■■■■■■■ 30-50%

GREEN GOAL VALUED / SPACE CONSTRAINED / MODEL ENTRENCHED -- harder ground:

Opposing the green goal: ■■ misdirected, fails

Insisting it be done justly: ■■■■■■■■■■ the real path

Community included / paid: ■■■■■■■■■■ achievable in part

The harm documented: ■■■■■■■■■■ the reliable foundation

How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Rwanda are **the compensation rights, the community-benefit promise, the benefit-sharing, and the donor safeguards** — used together, within the system, and honouring the green goal. The compensation and safeguards levers show the ceiling: a community harmed by a green project, invoking the state's own promise and the funders' rules, can genuinely win fair compensation, participation, and a share. The valued green goal and constrained space show the honest floor: the model is entrenched, and confrontation is limited. Most Rwandan efforts will sit between, and the honest lesson is that the levers here are real — able to win compensation, invoke the state's promise, press benefit-sharing, and enforce donor safeguards — but that opposing the green goal fails, the model endures, and the surest result is a community made whole and included, not a project stopped.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **The compensation rights and the community-benefit promise** — Rwanda's distinctive levers; the community's due and the state's own word.
2. **The donor safeguards** — the funders' social and environmental protections.
3. **The benefit-sharing and participation** — the community's real share and voice.
4. **The technical and institutional channels** — the within-system path to improvement.
5. **The documented harm** — the evidence, against the state's own promise, that grounds it all.

What These Campaigns Actually Show

A few honest patterns recur. **The state prizes its green, community-benefiting brand** — so holding it to that promise reaches it where it is sensitive. **Compensation is a real right** — imperfectly honoured, but a genuine claim. **Donors have safeguards** — the funders of the green projects carry protections communities can invoke. **Benefit-sharing is the state's own principle** — it can be pressed to be real. **But the green goal is valued and the model entrenched** — so the aim is justice in execution, not opposition to the goal. The through-line: **document the harm against the state's own promise; claim fair compensation and consent; press benefit-sharing and participation; invoke the donor safeguards; and honour the green goal — because a community that does can genuinely be made whole and included, while being honest that the green projects are valuable, the model is entrenched, and there is no stopping the green goal itself.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective effort begins by finding the exact project and harm — and the leverage, which here runs through the state's own promise and the community's rights. Vague grievance goes nowhere, and opposing the green goal is misdirected; an effort aimed at "this project harming this community by eviction or exclusion, against the state's own promise of community benefit, without fair compensation or consent, and in breach of the funders' safeguards, which the compensation rights, the benefit-sharing, and the safeguards can remedy" is a real, workable effort. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

1. **Who is harmed, and how?** This is the first question here. What **community is evicted, expropriated, excluded, or displaced** — the wetland neighbourhood, the expropriated plots, the community shut out of the conserved land.

2. What does the state's own promise require? What the **state's own commitment to community benefit** — its promise that green development serves communities — requires that this project is failing to deliver.

3. What compensation and consent are owed? What **fair compensation, genuine consultation, and consent** the rules require, and where they fall short.

4. How can the community share and participate? How the **benefit-sharing and participation** the state espouses can be made real for this community.

5. What donor safeguards apply, and how to work safely? Which **funders' safeguards** protect the community, and how the effort proceeds through official and international channels, within the constraints, with care.

A Worked Example

Suppose a wetland-restoration project — genuinely good for flood control — is evicting a neighbourhood and expropriating plots without fair compensation or real consultation, against the state's own promise that green projects benefit communities.

Working the five questions: **who is harmed? What does the promise require? What compensation and consent are owed? How can the community share?** And what safeguards apply, and how to work safely? The driver is the state and its green project, with the community-benefit promise, the compensation rights, the benefit-sharing, and the donor safeguards as the levers.

Within a season the effort has moved from "the green project will evict us and nothing can be done" to a real effort: document the harm against the state's own promise; claim fair compensation and genuine consultation; press for the community's share in the restored wetland's benefits; and invoke the international funder's safeguards — all within the system, with care, and without opposing the flood-control goal itself. That is a workable effort suited to Rwanda — one that insists a good project be done justly. Notice what the five questions accomplish, and how they suit a fight within a strong green state: they turn what might seem an impossible grievance — a community displaced by a project the state and the world both celebrate — into a set of specific, answerable questions, each attached to a lever that works with the state's own values rather than against its power or its green goal. The harm becomes a documentable displacement or exclusion. The standard becomes the state's own promise of community benefit. The due becomes the compensation and consent the rules require. The remedy becomes the benefit-sharing and participation the state espouses. And the outside weight becomes the safeguards the funders mandate. That translation — from a seemingly hopeless grievance against a celebrated project into a set of specific, rights-based claims pressed through the state's own commitments — is the first and most important thing a Rwandan effort does, because it moves the fight from resentment of the greening, where the community is both wrong and weak, onto the ground of the community's recognised rights and the state's own promises, where it has real and defensible purchase.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on — and here, distinctively, you document both the harm to the community and the gap between it and the state's own promise. A district, a compensation body, a funder, and the state itself all move on evidence — and in Rwanda, a clear record of the harm, the broken promise, and the owed compensation is precisely what an effort turns into a real result, so build it well. Build

your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Project, the Harm, and the Promise

Get the facts the case turns on. Identify the **project, its purpose, and the harm** — the restoration and the eviction, the development and the expropriation, the conservation and the exclusion — and, decisively here, **the gap between the harm and the state's own promise of community benefit**. Establish exactly **what the project is, whom it harms, and how that betrays the state's own promise**, because the harm-against-the-state's-own-promise is the case's foundation, and the surest ground in a green state.

Layer 2: The Harm, the Compensation, and the Consent

Document the harm and the community's due. Establish the **harm to the community** — the homes lost, the plots taken, the livelihoods displaced, the exclusion from conserved land — and, crucially, **the compensation and consent owed and unmet**: the inadequate or delayed compensation, the absent or nominal consultation, the lack of genuine consent. Draw on the community's own testimony, the compensation records, and the rules. This harm-and-compensation evidence turns the case into both a breach of the community's rights and a betrayal of the state's own promise.

Layer 3: The Harm, the Promise, the Safeguards, and the System

Finally, document the case and the path. Does the **harm** displace or exclude the community? How does it **breach the state's own promise** of community benefit? What **compensation, consent, and benefit-sharing** are owed? Which **donor safeguards** apply? And how will the effort **work through the system** — the districts, the funders, what channels exist — carefully? Each is a separate element, and together they make a case that presses the state on its own promise, claims the community's due, and invokes the funders' rules. This is the layer that most often decides these efforts, because a documented harm, a broken promise, an owed compensation, and an applicable safeguard are exactly what let a Rwandan community insist a green project be just. Build it well, and the community-benefit promise, the compensation rights, the benefit-sharing, and the donor safeguards become the community's genuine strength. One practical note on building this layer: the decisive move in a Rwandan case is to anchor every element of the harm to something the state itself has promised, recognised, or accepted, because that is what converts a grievance into an unanswerable claim in a green state. A community's bare complaint that it has been displaced is easily set against the national interest and the green goal; but a community's documented showing that it has been displaced without the compensation the state's own rules require, without the consultation the state's own procedures mandate, without the benefit-sharing the state's own principle promises, and without the safeguards the state's own funders demand, is a showing the state cannot dismiss without repudiating its own commitments and its own celebrated identity. Building this layer well therefore means, at every point, tying the harm not to abstract rights the state might contest but to the state's own promises, rules, and accepted safeguards, so that the case is built entirely on ground the state has already claimed as its own. That anchoring is the distinctive strength of a Rwandan effort, and the file should be built to exploit it.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Evidence in hand beats evidence you assume exists — and here you gather both the harm and the state's own promise. Here is where the material tends to live in a Rwandan effort, and how to get it — with the **harm, the broken promise, the compensation and consent, and the donor safeguards** at the center. Treat this as a checklist to work through, not a menu to admire.

The Project, Harm, and Promise Record

Start with the project and the promise it betrays. **The project plans, the expropriation and resettlement records, and the state's own commitments** establish what is intended and what is owed; the distinctive strengths here are the **state's own promise of community benefit** and its **stated principles** of participation and benefit-sharing, which are public and can be invoked. Establish the **project, the harm, and the gap from the state's own promise**, because the harm-against-the-promise is the case's spine. Establish exactly **who is harmed and how it betrays the state's word**, because a green state is exposed by its own broken promise.

The Compensation and Consent Evidence

This is the heart of the file. Gather the **compensation and consent evidence** — the compensation offered, delayed, or denied; the consultation absent or nominal; the consent lacking; the livelihoods and homes lost — and the **community's testimony** of the harm, drawing on the compensation records, the community's own accounts, and the rules. This compensation-and-consent evidence is what turns the harm into a claim the community can press, and a breach the state and the funders must answer.

The Benefit-Sharing and Safeguards Record

Document the levers of inclusion and protection. Gather the record of the **benefit-sharing principle** — the revenue-sharing and community-benefit commitments the state espouses — and how this community is excluded from it; and the **donor safeguards** — the social and environmental protections of the international funders of the project, their resettlement and grievance rules. A community that can show it is denied the benefit-sharing the state promises, and protected by safeguards the funders require, holds the levers that press both the state and its funders.

The Funder, Institutional, and International Record

Document the wider levers. Gather the record of the **international funders** of the green project and their grievance mechanisms; the **technical and institutional bodies** — the environment authority, the districts — through which the project runs; and the **international attention** on Rwanda's green and community-benefiting brand. A community joined to the funders' safeguards, working the institutional channels, and mindful of the international brand holds levers that reach the state where it is sensitive.

The People, the System, and the Care

Finally, map the human terrain and the careful path. Who is affected — the **evicted, expropriated, excluded, and displaced**, including the most marginalised communities — and who can act: the **community itself, the technical experts, the legal aid, the funders, what civil society exists**, since open dissent is constrained. And how does the effort **work through the system with care**, given the limits? A Rwandan effort is advanced largely through the compensation process, the funders' safeguards, and the state's own promise, within the constraints — so map that path deliberately, and let care for those involved and a realistic sense of the constrained space govern every step.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Here this step must be understood in the Rwandan way, because open, adversarial organising is constrained, and the "opposition" that works is a community pressing its rights and the state's own promise through official, technical, and international channels, not a movement against the green goal. The task is to

build a community — with what technical, legal, and international support it can find — that claims its compensation, its consent, and its share, and holds the state to its own promise, within the system.

Why the Within-System Community Is Decisive

In Rwanda, the community that can act is the one that works through the system and its own rights, because open opposition is constrained and opposing the green goal is misdirected. That community supplies what an effort runs on: the affected people who bear the harm, the testimony of what was lost, the claim to compensation and inclusion, and — distinctively — the moral force of holding a green state to its own promise of community benefit. When a community organises to claim its rights and the state's own promise, it becomes a genuine force. **A community that presses its rights and the state's own promise here is not a weaker substitute for open protest; it is the form redress can effectively and safely take in Rwanda — the real foundation of an effort, insisting a green state honour its word to the community.**

This is worth dwelling on, because the instinct to treat the greening itself as the enemy — to resent the eco-park or the conservation scheme that displaced you — is both understandable and, in Rwanda, strategically and morally mistaken. It is mistaken morally because the green goals are genuinely valuable: the restored wetland really does spare homes from flooding, the protected forest really does hold a treasure worth keeping, and a community that opposes these outright cedes the moral high ground and the truth. And it is mistaken strategically because a state that prizes its green identity will defend it fiercely against attack, but can far more readily concede that a good project should be done fairly. The community's strongest position, therefore, is the one that says: we support the green goal, and precisely because we support it, we insist it be achieved justly, with us and not over us. That stance is unassailable in a way that opposition to the greening never could be, because it asks only that the state be true to its own stated values, and it leaves the state no honourable way to refuse fair compensation, real consent, and a genuine share.

Finding the Community

Begin with those the harm touches and those who can help within the system — the **affected residents, the expropriated, the excluded, the technical and legal advisers, and the funders** — and treat the constraints on open dissent honestly, protecting those involved, especially the most vulnerable. Widen to others facing the same, and to sympathetic institutions. Name the shared stake — **our homes, our land, our compensation, and our share in the green future the state promises us** — because what is at stake is not the green goal but the community's rightful place in it. Frame the effort around inclusion and fairness, not opposition to the greening. There is real power in framing the cause this way, because it aligns the community with the state's own professed values rather than against them, and so gathers support that outright opposition never could. A community that says "stop the green project" invites the state to defend its green record and casts the community as an obstacle to progress and conservation. A community that says "include us in the green project, compensate us fairly, and let us share in its benefits as you promised" invites the state to live up to its own commitments and casts the community as a partner in a just green future. The second framing is not only safer in a constrained space; it is also truer, because most affected communities do not in fact object to flood control or gorilla conservation, but to being displaced and excluded without fairness. An effort that names this stake precisely — inclusion and fairness within the green goal, not opposition to it — is far harder for the state to dismiss or to cast as obstruction, and far more likely to win the community its rightful place.

Coalition-Building, Within the System

A community allied is stronger than a community alone, and in Rwanda it runs through the technical, legal, and international channels. Reach to the **technical and legal advisers; the international funders and**

their grievance mechanisms; the communities facing similar harm; and what civil society and human-rights support can be found, including for marginalised groups. Frame the coalition around the community-benefit promise, the compensation rights, the benefit-sharing, and the safeguards. Build breadth within the constraints, favouring the official, technical, and international channels over open confrontation, and protecting those involved.

Sustaining the Effort

Rwandan efforts are sustained through the community's rights, the state's promise, and the funders' safeguards. Keep the community **informed, connected, and careful**; mark real steps — a compensation improved, a consultation won, a share secured, a safeguard enforced. And keep the effort grounded in the state's own promise and the community's rights, which carry weight within the system. The effort that lasts is the one that works patiently through the system, claims the community's due, and holds the green state to its own promise of community benefit. Sustaining such an effort is helped, in the Rwandan case, by the concrete and rights-based nature of the claims it rests on. Unlike a protest movement, which depends on mobilisation and can be discouraged or dispersed, an effort built on specific, documented claims — this compensation owed and unpaid, this consultation required and skipped, this benefit-sharing promised and denied — rests on a foundation the state itself recognises in principle, and which does not evaporate when attention moves on. Each documented claim, each invoked safeguard, each pressed promise remains on the record, available to be built upon and pointed to, and accumulates into a standing case that the state and its funders must keep answering. The discipline is to keep the claims concrete, documented, and grounded in the state's own rules and promises, so that the effort rests not on the fragile energy of open dissent but on the durable ground of the community's recognised rights and the state's own commitments, which endure and compound within the system.

STEP 4: LEGAL, REGULATORY & COMMUNITY-RIGHTS CHALLENGES — THE COMPENSATION RIGHTS, THE BENEFIT-SHARING, AND THE DONOR SAFEGUARDS

This is where a Rwandan effort is realistically advanced — not through opposing the green goal, which is misdirected, nor open confrontation, which is constrained, but through the **community's compensation and consent rights, the benefit-sharing the state espouses, and the safeguards of the funders**, grounded in the state's own promise. Here the rights, benefit, and safeguard levers come together, because in Rwanda a green project that harms a community against the state's own promise is pressed through the community's rights and the funders' rules.

Setting Expectations Honestly

First, the honest truth. The levers are **real but work within a system the state controls, around projects it values**. The compensation rights are **real but imperfectly honoured**; the community-benefit promise is **genuine but unevenly delivered**; the donor safeguards are **real but depend on the funders' will**; and open challenge is **constrained**. What these levers realistically achieve is **fair compensation won, consent and consultation improved, benefit-sharing made real, and safeguards enforced** — real outcomes, if not the halting of a valued green project. Enter this front clear-eyed: the compensation rights, the benefit-sharing, and the donor safeguards are Rwanda's distinctive levers, strongest when the **harm and the broken promise are clearly documented** — but the green goal is valued, the model is entrenched, and space is constrained.

The Compensation and Consent Rights

The first and most distinctive front is the community's own rights. Rwanda's **expropriation and resettlement rules** provide for **compensation and consultation**, and a community harmed by a green or development project can press for **fair, prompt compensation and genuine consent** where these fall short. Claim the compensation owed, challenge inadequate valuations, and demand real consultation, because these are the community's rights under the state's own rules, and a green state is exposed when it displaces without honouring them. Use the compensation and consent rights firmly and within the system, because they are the community's most concrete due. It is worth being clear about both the power and the limits of this compensation front, honestly. Its power is real: compensation for expropriation is a recognised legal right, not a favour, so a claim for fair and prompt payment and for proper valuation stands on solid, concrete ground that even a strong state acknowledges in principle, and it is the community's most tangible and immediate remedy. Its limits are equally real: valuations are often disputed and can be set low, payment can be delayed, the process is administered by the same authorities carrying out the project, and a community pressing a claim does so from a position of considerable weakness against a strong state. Understanding both means using the compensation right for what it does best — securing the concrete, recognised due of a displaced community, and exposing the gap where that due is unmet — while pairing it always with the community-benefit promise, the benefit-sharing, and the donor safeguards that widen the claim from mere payment to genuine inclusion, and while pursuing it through whatever legal aid, technical help, and funder oversight can strengthen a weak claimant's hand against a strong state.

The Benefit-Sharing and the Community's Promise

The second front is the state's own promise of benefit. Rwanda espouses **benefit-sharing and community participation** — the revenue-sharing from conservation, the principle that green projects serve surrounding communities. Press for this to be **real** for the harmed community: a genuine share in the restored wetland's amenities, the conserved land's revenues, the development's gains, and a genuine voice in the project. Invoke the state's own promise that green development benefits communities, and insist this community be included, not displaced. This front turns the state's own community-benefit brand into a lever for the community's inclusion.

The Donor Safeguards and the International Brand

The third front is the funders and the world. The **international funders** of the green projects — the environment and development bodies — carry **social and environmental safeguards**, including resettlement protections and grievance mechanisms, which a harmed community can invoke to demand fair treatment and redress. And Rwanda's **international green and community-benefiting brand** makes it sensitive to showing that its green projects harm communities. Pursued together — the compensation and consent rights, the benefit-sharing, the donor safeguards, and the brand — these fronts are how a Rwandan community insists a green project be just, claiming its due and its share, through the system and with care, without opposing the green goal itself. It is worth understanding why these fronts reinforce one another so well in Rwanda's particular situation. The compensation and consent rights supply the community's concrete, legally recognised due. The community-benefit promise supplies the moral and political standard the state set itself and can be held to. The benefit-sharing supplies the principle by which the community claims not just compensation but a share and a voice. The donor safeguards supply an external standard the state has accepted from its funders. And the green brand supplies the reputational sensitivity that makes the state responsive to all of them. Each covers the others' limits: the rights where a concrete claim is needed, the promise where a moral standard helps, the benefit-sharing where inclusion is the goal, the safeguards where an outside standard adds weight, and the brand where reputation moves the state. A

community that grasps this division of labour, and presses each front through the system with care, makes the fullest use of the several levers that a celebrated green state uniquely provides — levers that work with the grain of the state's own professed values, and reach it where it genuinely responds.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Evidence does not speak for itself; you must aim it at each decider in the language that moves them. The same file of harm and broken promise becomes different arguments for the state, the districts, the funders, and the world. Translate deliberately, and always honouring the green goal.

For the State and Its Agencies

The state responds to **its own promise and its green, community-benefiting brand**. Frame the harm as a betrayal of the state's own word: here is a green project — which we support — harming the very community it promised to benefit. Give them the broken promise and the community's due, and ask that the project be made just: fair compensation, real consultation, a genuine share. Make it concrete: *here is your promise, here is the harm, here is how to keep your word*. This is the argument that holds a green state to its own commitment.

For the Districts and Local Authorities

The districts respond to **the rules and their responsibility to implement well**. Frame the harm as a failure of proper process: here is the compensation unpaid or undervalued, the consultation skipped, the resettlement botched. Give them the rules and the records, and ask for correct, fair implementation. A district shown its own process has failed the community can often remedy it within its mandate.

For the International Funders

The funders respond to **their safeguards and their reputation**. Frame the harm as a breach of the protections they require: here is a project you fund displacing a community without the safeguards you mandate. Give them the safeguard breach and the community's testimony, and invoke their grievance mechanism. A funder committed to do-no-harm, and mindful of its own reputation, is a powerful ally for redress.

For the World and the Green Brand

The world responds to **the gap between the green brand and the harm**. Translate the file into a story that respects the green goal but exposes the injustice: here is a celebrated green project displacing the community it should serve. Frame it as a call to make green development just, not to abandon it. Keep it accurate and fair; the green achievements are real, and overstatement or hostility to the greening would be both false and counterproductive. And be mindful of the sensitivities of a constrained space.

The Golden Rule

Never fabricate, never exaggerate, never oppose the green goal itself, and work within the system with care. Your credibility rests on the reality of the harm and the fairness of your ask — redress and inclusion, not the halting of a good project; and care for those involved matters in a constrained space. State the harm precisely, tie it to the state's own promise and the funders' safeguards, and ask for justice, not obstruction. An effort that is precise, fair, and honouring of the green goal is far harder to dismiss than one that overreaches or attacks the greening, and far safer than one that courts confrontation.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media and attention convert your evidence into pressure — and here, distinctively, the story is one of a celebrated green project that harms the community it should serve, told with care and respect for the green goal in a state with real red lines. The story — the eviction beneath the eco-park, the family expropriated for the green city — is one that resonates, if told fairly.

Why Media Matters

The state, the districts, the funders, and the world behave differently when the gap between the green brand and the harm is visible. Media does three things here: it **informs and connects the affected community and its advisers**, it **raises the stakes** for a state that prizes its green and community-benefiting reputation, and it **reaches the funders and the world** who expect green projects to serve communities. But Rwanda is a state with limited media freedom and real red lines, so the media effort runs largely through **the international funders and development media, careful factual documentation, and human-rights channels**, rather than confrontational domestic press — and with care for those involved.

Crafting Your Narrative

Lead with the gap between promise and harm, respectfully. The strongest frame is fair and pointed: *a celebrated green project — which the community supports — is displacing that same community without the fair compensation, consent, and share the state itself promises, and the funders require*. Put the broken promise and the community's due first, and the respect for the green goal throughout, because the injustice lands hardest against the state's own word, and hostility to the greening would discredit the case. Keep it scrupulously accurate and fair; the green achievements are real, and the case is about justice in execution. The Rwandan story is powerful because it holds a green state to its own promise. This is the heart of the matter, and it is worth stating plainly why it gives a Rwandan effort its distinctive force. The power of the case lies not in opposition from outside but in the state's own promise turned into a standard: it is the state itself that has declared green development a national value, the state itself that has promised these projects will benefit surrounding communities, the state itself that espouses benefit-sharing and community participation, and the state itself that then, in the execution, displaces and excludes the very people it pledged to serve. An effort that opposed the greening would forfeit the truth and invite the state's fiercest defence. An effort that instead holds up the state's own promise against its own conduct — its own commitment to community benefit, its own rules on compensation, its own principle of benefit-sharing — asks only that the state be true to what it professes, which is a far harder thing for a state proud of its green identity to refuse, and a far safer thing for a community to demand. That is why the appeal to the state's own promise, rather than opposition to its goal, is not merely a matter of tone but the strategic core of the entire Rwandan approach.

Choosing Your Channels

Match the channel to the audience, and to the constraints. **The international funders and their accountability channels** for the safeguard breach; **development and human-rights media** for the world; **careful factual documentation** for the record; and the **technical and institutional channels** for redress. Because Rwanda's media space is constrained, the funder and international channels matter most — a celebrated green project harming its own community, documented fairly, is the story's distinctive power.

A Few Cautions

Stay accurate, fair, and respectful of the green goal — the aim is justice and inclusion, not to attack the greening or to endanger those involved. Frame the story around the broken promise and the community's due, and be mindful of the constraints on dissent and the real red lines of a tightly organised state. Handle the government, the politics, and the country's history factually, respectfully, and with great care, and never instrumentalise sensitive matters. And sustain the story through the ongoing pursuit of redress. Above all, let the fair, respectful case — a green state held to its promise of community benefit — carry the story, because that is where a Rwandan effort is strongest and safest.

EMAILS & LETTERS: TEMPLATES THAT WORK

Templates save time and prevent mistakes, but adapt every one — insert the real project, the real harm, and the real right, keep it factual, honour the green goal, and work within the system with care. Here the compensation rights, and the state's own promise, win.

8A: Requesting Information

Subject: Request for information — [project] and our community

To [district / authority / agency],

I am writing on behalf of [community] regarding [project] and its effects on our community, including [eviction / expropriation / exclusion]. We support the environmental goals of the project. To understand and respond, we respectfully request the **project and resettlement plans**, the **compensation and valuation records**, and the **consultation and benefit-sharing arrangements** for the affected community.

We would be grateful for a response by [date].

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8B: Compensation and Consent Claim

Subject: Fair compensation and consultation for [community] under [project]

To the [district / authority],

Our community, affected by [project], has not received the fair compensation and genuine consultation the rules require: [describe the shortfall]. We support the project's environmental aims, and we respectfully claim the **fair, prompt compensation and real consultation** owed to us, so that a good project does not fall unjustly on our community. We attach the documentation.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8C: Invoking the State's Community-Benefit Promise

Subject: Ensuring [project] benefits our community, as promised

To [agency / authority],

Rwanda's commitment is that green development benefits the communities it touches. We ask that [project] honour that promise for our community: that we be included, not displaced, and that we share in [the restored wetland's amenities / the conserved land's revenues / the project's gains]. We support the green

goal and ask only our rightful place in it. We attach our proposal.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8D: Letter to an International Funder

Subject: Safeguards concern regarding [project] funded by [funder]

Dear [funder / grievance mechanism],

We write regarding [project], which you fund, and which is displacing our community without the fair compensation, consultation, and resettlement protections your safeguards require. We support the project's environmental aims but seek the fair treatment your safeguards mandate. We respectfully request review through your grievance mechanism, and provide the documentation and our testimony.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8E: Requesting Benefit-Sharing / Participation

Subject: Our community's participation and share in [project]

To [agency / district / park authority],

As [project] proceeds, we respectfully request that our community genuinely participate in its planning and share in its benefits — [the revenues, the amenities, the employment] — in keeping with Rwanda's benefit-sharing principle. Our inclusion will make the project both juster and more sustainable. We offer our participation and our proposals.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8F: Letter for a Marginalised or Excluded Community

Subject: Inclusion and rights of [community] affected by [project]

To [authority / funder / human-rights body],

Our community, [including its most marginalised members], has been [excluded from / displaced by] [project] without adequate compensation, consultation, or a share in its benefits. We respectfully request that our rights, our compensation, and our inclusion be honoured, in keeping with the state's own commitments and the funders' safeguards. We attach our account.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8G: Media / Documentation Pitch

Subject: A green project and the community it should serve at [location]

Dear [journalist / editor],

At [location], a celebrated green project — which the community supports — is displacing that same community without the fair compensation, consent, and share the state itself promises and the funders require. There is a careful, fair story here about making green development just, and we can provide the documentation, the community's testimony, and an account that honours the green goal while exposing the injustice.

Sincerely,

[Name, community, contact]

8H: Rallying the Community, Within the System

Subject: Our place in the green future — let us claim it together

Dear neighbours,

Our homes and land are affected by [project], a green project we support but which is falling unjustly on us. Together — by documenting the harm, claiming our compensation and consultation, insisting on our share, and holding the state to its own promise that green development benefits communities — we can seek justice and our rightful place, through the proper channels and with care. Please join us: share your account, and add your voice.

With respect,

[Name, community]

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Sometimes a harm is acute — an eviction notice served, an expropriation ordered, a resettlement begun, a community shut out — and you cannot run the full effort. Triage to the levers that work fastest and safest here, which means the compensation claim, the state's own promise, and the funders' safeguards.

The First 48 Hours

Establish the essentials — through the system: **who is harmed, and what compensation and consent are owed**. Identify the immediate step — an **eviction, an expropriation, a resettlement, an exclusion** — because that is what you must address first. Reach the **legal or technical advisers, the district, and any international funder** at once, because in Rwanda the compensation claim and the funders' safeguards are the fastest routes to real, and safer, redress — and frame the concern around the community's due and the state's own promise, not against the green goal.

The Fastest-Moving Levers

Some levers work faster than others. **The compensation and consent claim** can be made at once, as the community's concrete right. **The state's own promise** of community benefit can be invoked immediately. **The funders' grievance mechanism** can be alerted quickly. **The demand for consultation** can be raised before a step is final. These outpace the slower work of securing benefit-sharing and international attention — which must follow — because the compensation claim and the safeguards can be brought to bear immediately. Above all, if compensation or consent is being skipped, act fast to claim it, because that is often the quickest lawful brake.

Emergency Coalition-Building

You cannot build a full coalition overnight, but here you can reach the advisers and funders fast. Reach immediately to the **legal and technical advisers, the district, the international funder, and any human-rights support**. A community claiming its compensation, invoking the state's promise, and alerting the funder is the most a rapid Rwandan effort can do — and these can move fast within the system. Speed favours the prepared: know the harm, the right, and the safeguard before the crisis breaks, and work through the system with care.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Here, honestly, the system is tilted by a strong, top-down developmental state that pursues genuinely valued green and development goals with little room for open dissent, so that a community's rights can be overridden by a project the state deems in the national interest. This is Rwanda's central, honest truth, and the whole guide has been shaped by it. Name it plainly, because pretending the state does not prize its green goals, or that dissent is free, or that the model can be opposed head-on, would be false.

Recognising a Tilted Field

The signs are specific and honest. **The green goal is valued** — the state pursues its green and development projects with genuine conviction and international acclaim. **The model is top-down** — decisions are made centrally and implemented firmly, with limited community voice. **Space is constrained** — open dissent and independent civil society are limited. **Yet the state prizes its community-benefiting brand** — it professes to serve communities, which is a lever. This is a tilt of a strong, top-down, green developmental state, and an effort here works it through the state's own promise, the community's rights, and the funders' safeguards, within the constraints, not through open confrontation or opposition to the green goal.

Strategies for a Tilted Field

When the field is tilted, use the levers within the system and the state's own commitments. Lean on the **compensation and consent rights**, the community's concrete due; the **state's own promise** of community benefit, holding it to its word; the **benefit-sharing**, pressing for the community's real share; the **donor safeguards**, invoking the funders' protections; and the **respect for the green goal**, which keeps the effort credible and safe. Ask not that the project stop but that it be just, because a green state can concede fairness far more readily than it can concede its goal. And build the record and the relationships over time, because within-system credibility accumulates into real influence. A tilted field here is worked through the state's own promise and the community's rights, with care, not against the green goal or the state head-on.

The Honest Possibility of Losing

You may achieve little — the project may proceed, the compensation may stay thin, the community may be moved — and this guide will not pretend otherwise; the green goal is valued and the state is strong. But here the work is rarely wholly wasted: the **harm was documented against the state's own promise, the compensation was claimed, the safeguards were invoked, and the community's due was pressed** — and every compensation improved, every consultation won, every share secured, every safeguard enforced makes a real difference to real families. Press for justice; even if the project proceeds, the claim you pressed and the promise you invoked will shape how this and the next project treat the community, because a state that stakes its name on serving communities cannot forever be shown to displace them.

WHEN IT'S NOT CORRUPTION BUT TOP-DOWN POWER

In Rwanda, the honest reckoning is unusual, because the country is widely regarded as relatively free of the petty and grand corruption that afflicts many states — a genuine achievement. The problem here is not graft but the imbalance of power between a strong, purposeful, top-down state and the individual community: rights overridden in the name of the national interest, decisions made centrally with little community voice, and a well-intentioned developmental drive that can run over the people in its path. This must be approached with care and fairness, and the route runs through the community's rights, the state's own promise, and the funders' safeguards.

Telling Top-Down Power from Ordinary Governance

In many states the concern is corruption; in Rwanda it is more often the sheer imbalance of power. The marks are specific: **the community's rights overridden for a project deemed in the national interest, decisions made centrally with limited local voice, a strong state and a weak individual claimant, and a developmental purpose that can eclipse the community's due.** Be fair and precise: **credit the state's genuine achievements and low corruption, and distinguish the ordinary exercise of strong governance from a real failure to compensate, consult, or include,** and rely on the community's rights and the state's own promise, because in a constrained space these are safer and more credible than accusation.

Responding to Top-Down Power — Through the System, Carefully

Where the imbalance harms a community, the response runs through the community's rights and the state's own commitments. Use the **compensation and consent rights** to claim the community's concrete due. Use the **state's own promise** of community benefit to insist the strong state honour its word to the weak claimant. Use the **funders' safeguards** to bring an outside standard the state has accepted. And use **respect for the green goal** to keep the effort credible and safe. Document carefully and protect those involved, because in a constrained space the record must be rigorous and the people shielded, especially the most vulnerable. Route the effort through rights, promise, and safeguards — not through open confrontation with a strong state.

A Note on Safety and Care

This note matters throughout. Rwanda is a tightly organised state with real red lines around politics, security, and criticism of the government, and while claiming compensation and inclusion is more tolerated than overt political dissent, the work must still be done with real care. So favour the **legal, technical, and international channels** over open confrontation; frame the work around the community's rights and the state's own promise, not around challenging authority; protect individuals, especially the most vulnerable and marginalised, whose position could be jeopardised; handle the government, the politics, and the country's history — including its most sensitive chapters — factually, respectfully, and with the utmost care, and never instrumentalise them. Care here is not timidity; it is the recognition that the effective and safe path in Rwanda runs through the community's rights, the state's own promise, and the funders' safeguards, and that pressing too openly can cost vulnerable people dearly while achieving less than patient work within the system.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps in this guide are written in sequence but run in parallel, each feeding the others — all through the system and the state's own promise. Here is how they fit into a single, careful Rwandan effort.

The Parallel Effort

From the start, the five run together, within the system. **Documentation** builds the harm-and-broken-promise file. **Target identification** aims it at the levers. **Local opposition**, understood as the within-system community, claims its rights. **Legal, regulatory, and community-rights** work presses the compensation, the benefit-sharing, and the safeguards. **Media**, largely through funders and international channels, carries the fair case. The harm-and-promise feeds all five at once — a documented harm is a compensation claim, a broken promise, a safeguard breach, and a fair story together. Run in parallel, they compound; run one at a time, they stall — and here, working through a green state's own promise, they compound into real redress within the system.

A Rough Timeline

Early (weeks 1–8): establish the harm and the broken promise; identify the compensation rights, the benefit-sharing, and the safeguards; begin documentation and reach the advisers and funders. **Middle (months 2–18):** claim the compensation and consultation; invoke the state's promise and the funders' safeguards; press for benefit-sharing and participation; and build the record. **Later (months and years):** secure the redress and inclusion, hold the state to its promise for this and future projects, and keep building the community's standing within the system. A Rwandan effort is patient and works through the system, and its fruits — compensation, consultation, inclusion — are gradual; pace it accordingly, and let care and respect for the green goal govern every step.

The Core Discipline

Through it all, hold the discipline that gives these efforts their force: **document the harm against the state's own promise; claim fair compensation and consent; press benefit-sharing and participation; invoke the donor safeguards; and honour the green goal.** The community that presses all five, working through a green state's own promise, and with care, is the one that can genuinely be made whole and included — the kind of justice a strong, top-down, but community-professing state allows.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Defending a community in Rwanda is genuinely difficult, and unusual, because the harm often comes wrapped in genuinely valued green development, and because the state is strong, top-down, and sparing of open dissent, and this guide has been honest about that from its first line: the green projects are valuable, the state has real reasons, the space is constrained, and the model is entrenched. And yet the effort is far from futile, because the state prizes its promise that green development benefits communities, the compensation and consent rights are real, the benefit-sharing is the state's own principle, and the funders carry safeguards — and those levers of the community-benefit promise, the compensation rights, the benefit-sharing, and the donor safeguards are real.

Some honest truths hold across every effort here. **The state prizes its green, community-benefiting brand — so holding it to its promise reaches it where it is sensitive. Compensation and consent are real rights, if imperfectly honoured. The funders carry safeguards the state has accepted. But the green goal is valued, the model entrenched, and the aim is justice in execution, not opposition to the goal.** Hold both truths at once: real, distinctive, within-system levers grounded in the state's own promise, and the honest weight of a strong, green, top-down state.

Above all, keep the discipline — and the care — that give these efforts their force. Document the harm against the state's own promise. Claim fair compensation and consent. Press benefit-sharing and

participation. Invoke the donor safeguards. And honour the green goal — because in a celebrated green state, an effort that insists green development be just for the community, through the system and with care, honouring the green goal while claiming the community's due, is the one that is both effective and just.

Rwanda is admired across the world as a green model, and deservedly so in many ways: it has brought its gorillas back, banned the plastic bag, cleaned its capital, and is restoring the wetlands that guard it from flood; this guide has honoured those achievements and hidden none of them. But the same strong, top-down drive that delivers them can fall heavily on the communities in its path — the neighbourhood evicted for the eco-park, the family expropriated for the green city, the community excluded from the conserved land — and it can do so, painfully, in the name of a green good the community itself supports. This guide has not pretended the green projects are anything but valuable, or that the state lacks reasons, or that a tightly organised state's political space is open, and there is no landmark victory here to promise you. But the very thing that makes Rwanda a green model is also the lever: a state that stakes its name on green development that benefits communities can be held to that promise, asked not to abandon its green goals but to honour its word to the people those goals affect — with fair compensation, genuine consent, a real share, and the safeguards its funders require. There is no opposing the green goal, and no easy victory in a constrained space; this guide has said so throughout, and insisted on care for those who act. But the homes and lands and dignity of Rwanda's communities are worth defending, the levers that run through a green state's own promise are real, and the patient, careful work of documenting the harm, claiming the community's due, and insisting that green development be just is one a community can genuinely do — from within the system, and win its rightful place in the green future. So can you.